

Left (top to bottom) Café Tomaselli, Austria's oldest "Viennese coffee house"; Schwarzwälder Kirschtorte, or Black Forest gâteau; coffee and the classic Sacher Torte.

Below (top to bottom) A tempting display of *torten* in a Viennese café with, far right, the tall, ring-shaped *Guglhupf*; afternoon coffee and cake in Café Gerbeaud in Budapest



Café Adler

Hauptstrasse 52, Triberg; www.hotel-cafe-adler.de

An understated café and patisserie with some of the best cakes in the region, which can be enjoyed in its pastel interiors or outside in a lovely little courtyard. They have a tremendous line in decorative confectionery items that make perfect gifts.

Café Decker

Hauptstrasse 70, Staufen; www.cafe-decker.de

The star café of the southwestern Black Forest region has a lovely riverside outdoor terrace and around 40 stunning fresh *torten* every day. It is also a first-class chocolatier and ice-cream maker, but beware: it gets packed at peak times.

ZURICH, SWITZERLAND

Chocolate and confectionery are a major export for the Swiss, so it's no surprise that they take great pride in their cakes too. There is a touch of the French *pâtissier* in their smaller and more delicate confections.

Confiserie Sprüngli

Bahnhofstrasse 21; www.spruengli.ch

This is run by a world-famous confectioner who's famed for *Luxemburgerli*, a sugar-based cookie much like a French *macaron*. But there are plenty of *torten* to choose from too and everything is lovingly handmade using the best ingredients – though some might gripe about the high prices.

On the Menu

Torten are rarely labeled and it's often simply a case of picking something that catches the eye. Even so, it's worth bearing the classics in mind and seeking them out.

Dobos Torte Simple but elegant five-layered Hungarian chocolate buttercream sponge cake from the 1880s. Often coated with ground nuts and topped with an angled wedge of caramel.

Frankfurter Kranz (Frankfurt wreath) Classic rum-flavored cake with layers of buttercream filling and a single layer of jelly.

Herrentorte (Gentlemen's cake) A term used for a range of cakes made with large amounts of dark chocolate, particularly in their icing.

Linzer Torte A Christmas favorite from the 17th century with a latticework top and chopped almonds around the edge. The pastry is a crumbly combination of lemon, cinnamon, and ground nuts, and its most common filling is red-currant jelly.

Café Bauer

Badenerstrasse 355; www.cafe-bauer.ch

This has been a local institution since the 1920s, thanks to its great selection of freshly made *torten* as well as a fine range of French-style patisserie. It also has delicious versions of everyday bakery products, such as pretzels and croissants.

BUDAPEST, HUNGARY

As the joint capital of the Austro-Hungarian empire, Budapest shared much of Vienna's culture, and the "coffee and cake" tradition took root here at about the same time. The results are almost as venerable.

Café Gerbeaud

Vörösmarty tér 7–8; www.gerbeaud.hu

A large and noble coffeehouse where hanging drapes and extraordinary chandeliers dominate interiors that have barely changed since its foundation in 1858. Despite seating over 300 people, a relaxed atmosphere prevails and the *torten* are impeccable.

Konditorei Ruszwurm

Szentháromság utca. 7; www.ruszwurm.hu

This tiny and charmingly well-preserved 1820s coffeehouse sits on Budapest's Castle Hill and has a superb cake selection, including traditional Hungarian favorites such as the *Dobos* and the walnut *Esterházy* with its succulent marbled icing.

Obsttorte (Fruit *torte*) Usually the simplest-looking *torte*, this fruit tart generally uses glazed fruits (often strawberries) and is sometimes decorated with toasted nuts.

Prinzregententorte (Prince Regent Cake) A layered *torte* with chocolate buttercream and apricot preserve, often dubbed the "Sacher Torte of Bavaria," where it's particularly popular.

Sacher Torte This classic, dark chocolate cake with a layer of apricot jelly was invented by 16-year-old apprentice pastry chef Franz Sacher in 1832; the recipe remains a closely guarded secret.

Schwarzwälder Kirschtorte (Black Forest cherry cake) This is probably the most famous cake. Layers of whipped cream and Kirsch-flavored chocolate cake studded with maraschino cherries are topped with dark chocolate curls.

Zuger Kirschtorte (Zug cherry cake) Swiss *torte* made from ground almonds and hazelnuts, filled with Kirsch and buttercream and topped with a dusting of icing sugar.